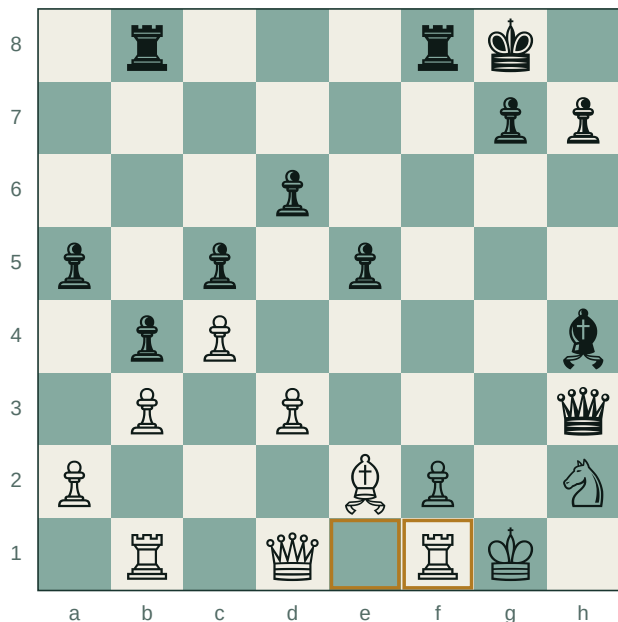


Capture the defender: Black, move 26

Capture the defender

Black to move



Previous move: 26.Rf1. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

26...Bxf2+ 27. Rxf2 Rxf2 28. Kxf2 Qxh2+

26...Bxf2+ Check restricts White to 2 legal replies here. The move also takes the pawn on f2. Recorded reply: **27.Rxf2**.

27...Rxf2 The rook captures the rook on f2. From f2 it attacks knight on h2 and bishop on e2. Recorded reply: **28.Kxf2**.

28...Qxh2+ Check restricts White to 4 legal replies here. The move also takes the knight on h2.

At the end, nominal material is White 21 / Black 21 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +1. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +1: the balance goes from -1 to +0. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on g1. Look for a defender that can be displaced or overloaded.